

Close with clarity—not pressure.

A practical field guide for better sales conversations, clear decisions,
and confident next steps.

How to use this kit

This is a working guide, not a performance to memorize. Read the principles once, choose one close to practice, and use the checklist before your next qualified conversation. The scripts are deliberately adaptable: replace bracketed words with your customer's language, your actual offer, and your real process.

One rule: never use a line that is untrue. A strong close is clear, relevant, and easy for a buyer to answer.

Contents

1. Closing as a natural next step
2. Readiness before the ask
3. Five core closes
4. Understand the business you sell
5. Objections and clean follow-through
6. Closing checklist and practice plan

The rep's job at the close

Your job is not to “win” a conversation. It is to help a qualified buyer decide whether the problem is important, whether your offer fits, and what should happen next. That may be a purchase, a pilot, a review with another stakeholder, or a respectful no.

1 • Closing is a natural next step

Closing is the moment you ask the buyer to turn shared understanding into a decision or a defined next action. It should not appear from nowhere. The conversation earns the close by clarifying the current situation, the cost of leaving it unchanged, the desired outcome, and the fit of your offer.

A pressure trick asks for movement the buyer has not earned. A useful close makes the decision visible.

The four-part path

1. Explore: What is happening now? What is getting in the way?
2. Connect: What matters about solving it? Where does your offer fit?
3. Confirm: “If we can do X, would that address the issue you described?”
4. Advance: Ask for the appropriate next step and name the logistics.

Before you close, check:

- The buyer has described a real problem or goal.
- You understand the decision criteria and who is involved.
- You have explained the relevant value without exaggerating.
- The next step is appropriate to the buying stage.
- The buyer can say no or ask for time without being cornered.

Language that keeps the close clean

Use: “Based on what you told me...” “Would it make sense to...” “What would you need to decide?” “If it is not a fit, that is useful to know too.” Avoid: “You have to decide today,” “This is your only chance,” or any claim about results you cannot substantiate.

2 • Readiness before the ask

A close works best when it follows evidence of fit. Look for specific signals, not just enthusiasm: the buyer asks about implementation, timing, terms, integrations, or what happens after purchase. A friendly tone alone is not a buying signal.

Use a trial question

A trial close is a low-pressure check of fit. It tells you whether to proceed, clarify, or revisit the problem.

Script: “If [the solution addresses the priority you described] and the implementation works with [their constraint], would you be comfortable moving to [next step]?”

If they say yes, confirm the details and advance. If they hesitate, ask: “What part would you want to examine first?” Treat hesitation as information, not resistance.

Three questions that prevent premature closing

- “What would make this a worthwhile change for you?”
- “Who else needs to be confident before this can move forward?”
- “What would stop you from taking the next step, even if the fit looks right?”

A simple qualification snapshot

Write down one sentence for each: Problem: ____ Impact: ____ Desired change: ____ Decision process: ____
Timing: ____ Fit evidence: ____

3 • The Assumptive Close

When to use it: Use it when the buyer has clearly confirmed fit and is discussing execution details. It treats the agreed next step as practical—not the purchase as inevitable.

Word-for-word starting point:

“You mentioned the team wants to start with [scope]. I’ll set up [next step] for [date]. Before I send that over, is there anything about the plan or terms you want me to clarify?”

Watch-out: Do not use this to skip consent. If the buyer has not agreed to the direction, ask a direct decision question instead.

Adaptation: Adapt: “Would [date] or [date] work better for kickoff?”

After the ask

Stop talking. Give the buyer room to answer. Then reflect the answer: “That makes sense.” “Let’s look at that.” “A no is okay; I want the decision to be clear.”

4 • The Alternative-Choice Close

When to use it: Use it when the buyer has decided to proceed or when two genuinely suitable paths remain. Offer choices that reflect real differences, not a fake choice between yes and yes.

Word-for-word starting point:

“We can start with [Option A], which covers [need] in [timeframe], or [Option B], which adds [different need] and uses [different timeframe]. Which is the better fit for how you want to begin?”

Watch-out: Only present options you can actually deliver. Explain the meaningful trade-off.

Adaptation: Adapt: “Would you prefer the standard plan or the version with [specific add-on]?”

After the ask

Stop talking. Give the buyer room to answer. Then reflect the answer: “That makes sense.” “Let’s look at that.” “A no is okay; I want the decision to be clear.”

5 • The Summary Close

When to use it: Use it when the conversation has uncovered several priorities and the buyer needs to hear the case in one clean picture. Keep it in their words.

Word-for-word starting point:

“Let me make sure I have this right. You want to [goal], the current [problem] is affecting [impact], and you need [criteria]. We agreed that [offer] addresses [relevant fit]. If that summary is accurate, shall we [next step]?”

Watch-out: Do not turn the summary into a speech full of features. Pause after each important point and invite correction.

Adaptation: Adapt: “What, if anything, would you change in that summary?”

After the ask

Stop talking. Give the buyer room to answer. Then reflect the answer: “That makes sense.” “Let’s look at that.” “A no is okay; I want the decision to be clear.”

6 • The Trial Close

When to use it: throughout a conversation, especially after explaining one important part of the offer. It tests whether the solution is solving the right problem before you stack on more information.

Script: “How does that approach line up with what you need?”

If positive: “Good. If we can also resolve [remaining concern], would you be ready to [next step]?”

If uncertain: “What feels off or incomplete?”

The trial close is not a disguised demand. It is a diagnostic. Use the answer to decide what to explain next.

7 • The Honest Urgency Close

When to use it: only when a real, buyer-relevant deadline or capacity constraint exists and you can state the facts plainly. Examples include a published enrollment date, a real implementation window, or a documented pricing change.

Script: “You said [date/event] matters because [reason]. To be ready by then, we would need [real step] by [actual date]. If that timing works for you, would you like to complete [next step] now? If it does not, we can look at the next available option.”

Never invent urgency. Do not imply a deadline, limited supply, price change, or “last chance” if it is not real. The buyer deserves an accurate choice, including the choice to wait.

8 • Understand the business you sell

Product knowledge tells you what a thing does. Business understanding tells you why it matters, where it fits, and what could make it a poor choice. Reps who understand both their own business and the buyer's business can ask sharper questions and avoid promising the wrong thing.

Know your own offer

Be able to explain: the customer and use case it is designed for; the problem it addresses; what it includes and excludes; implementation effort and time; pricing and terms; support and handoffs; proof you are allowed to use; and the clearest reasons it may not be a fit.

Know the buyer's operating reality

Ask questions that reveal priorities without pretending to be an expert in their business:

- “How does this problem show up in your week?”
- “What does it interrupt, delay, or put at risk?”
- “How is the decision usually made?”
- “What constraint matters most: time, budget, adoption, compliance, or something else?”
- “What would a sensible first step look like?”

Map the value honestly

Current state → consequence → desired state → relevant capability → proof or verification → next action. If you cannot connect a capability to a stated priority, leave it out. If the buyer needs proof you do not have, say what you can verify and by when.

Example: “You are losing time when handoffs are unclear. The useful part of our offer here is the shared workflow and owner reminders—not every feature in the package. Let's test that against your process with [specific step].”

9 • Objections are information

An objection can mean a missing fact, a real constraint, a competing priority, or a polite no. Do not argue with it. Clarify what kind of issue it is, respond only to that issue, then check whether it is resolved.

The four-step response

Hear: Let the buyer finish.

Reflect: “It sounds like implementation time is the concern.”

Clarify: “Is that the main issue, or is there another piece?”

Respond and check: “Here is what we can do... Would that address it?”

Useful scripts

“I need to think about it.”

“Of course. What part would you like to think through—fit, timing, terms, or something else?”

“It costs too much.”

“Understood. Is the concern the total budget, the timing of the spend, or whether the value justifies it? I do not want to guess.”

“Send me information.”

“Happy to. To make it useful, what decision will the information help you make? And when should we review it together?”

“I need to ask [person].”

“That makes sense. What will they want to know, and would it help to include them in a short review?”

If it is not a fit

Say so plainly: “Based on [constraint], I do not think this is the right option today. If that changes, here is what would make it worth revisiting.” A clean no protects trust and your time.

10 • Closing checklist

Before the conversation

- ☐ I know the customer and use case this offer serves.
- ☐ I can state what it does, does not do, costs, and requires.
- ☐ I have a hypothesis about the buyer's priority, not an assumption presented as fact.
- ☐ I know the decision stage and the appropriate next step.

During the conversation

- ☐ I asked questions and wrote down the buyer's exact language.
- ☐ I connected only relevant capabilities to stated priorities.
- ☐ I checked fit before asking for movement.
- ☐ I identified stakeholders, criteria, constraints, and timing.
- ☐ I answered what was asked without flooding the buyer with features.

At the close

- ☐ I named one clear action.
- ☐ I used a close that fits the stage (trial, summary, choice, assumptive, or honest urgency).
- ☐ I paused and let the buyer answer.
- ☐ I captured the decision, owner, date, and dependencies.
- ☐ I did not use a claim, deadline, or promise I cannot support.

After the conversation

- ☐ I sent a concise recap: goal, agreed points, open question, next action, owner, date.
- ☐ I updated the CRM or tracking system while details are fresh.
- ☐ I scheduled the agreed follow-up instead of relying on memory.
- ☐ I recorded what I learned for the next conversation.

11 • Practice and quick reference

A five-minute drill

Choose one real opportunity. Write the buyer's problem in their words. Write the desired outcome. Select one close. Say it aloud once in your natural voice. Remove any phrase you would not say to a person. Then add the exact date and owner for the next step.

Role-play prompts

- The buyer is interested but has not named a priority.
- Two stakeholders want different outcomes.
- A real implementation window ends on a known date.
- The buyer asks for a proposal but avoids a review date.
- The offer is not a fit under the buyer's current constraint.

Quick-reference card

Trial: "How does that line up with what you need?"

Summary: "You want [goal], the issue is [impact], and you need [criteria]. Shall we [next step]?"

Choice: "Would [real option A] or [real option B] fit better?"

Assumptive: "I'll set up [agreed step] for [date]. What should I clarify first?"

Honest urgency: "To be ready by [real date], we need [step] by [date]. Would you like to proceed?"

Final reminder

Clarity is a service. Ask for the next step when the buyer has enough information, make the path easy to understand, and leave room for a real answer. The best close is the one that makes the decision—and the follow-through—clear.

© Close Academy • Original training material • For educational use